

---

## Meeting assets for Audel & Andy SDRT are ready!

---

Zoom <no-reply@zoom.us>  
To: sparkyflashrebob@gmail.com

Mon, May 18, 2026 at 7:52 PM



---

## Meeting assets for Audel & Andy SDRT are ready!

[View meeting recap](#)

---

### Meeting summary

#### Key Takeaways

- Andy and Audel held a personal check-in session covering life updates, spiritual practice, and philosophical reflections.
- Both participants shared updates on family situations, including Andy's daughter in rehab, an unexpected pregnancy, and Audel's son graduating kindergarten.
- Both Andy and Audel discussed their shared meditation practice and its benefits for managing stress and grounding.
- Andy shared insights from a recent visit to Abayagiri monastery, including wisdom from the Theravada Buddhist tradition.
- Andy referenced the book *The Death of Expertise* by Thomas Nichols as a personal self-reflection prompt.
- The group conducted a 15-minute shared meditation session during the meeting.
- The next meeting (Memorial Day week) was canceled; the following session is scheduled for June 1st.

#### Discussed Topics

##### Personal Life Updates

Andy and Audel exchanged personal updates at the start of the meeting, covering family challenges and life transitions.

- **Details**
  - Andy: His daughter is currently in rehabilitation, located approximately 2.5 hours away, requiring regular travel.
  - Andy: Another daughter is pregnant, an unplanned situation he is approaching with acceptance.
  - Andy: Noted concerns about the reliability and emotional stability of his daughter's partner.
  - Andy: Mentioned that retirement has been unexpectedly busy.
  - Audel: Shared that the past two months have been stressful with a lot going on personally and professionally.
  - Audel: His wife is experiencing back pain from a long drive.





- Audel: Their oldest dog has been diagnosed with congestive heart failure and is on medication; they recently got a new puppy.
- Audel: His son is graduating kindergarten on Wednesday.
- **Conclusion**
  - Both participants acknowledged the weight of current personal circumstances and the importance of taking things week by week.
  - Andy encouraged Audel to celebrate the joyful moments, such as his son's graduation.

## End of School Year and Summer School

Audel provided an update on the school calendar and upcoming summer commitments.

- **Details**
  - Audel: Last day with students is Wednesday, followed by a graduation ceremony on Thursday and a staff workday on Friday.
  - Audel: Summer school begins June 1st, with a prep day the preceding Friday.
  - Audel: Summer school is paid hourly at \$40/hour, which he finds motivating.
  - Andy: Noted that paid prep days make sense to ensure staff are ready.
- **Conclusion**
  - Audel will have approximately one week off before summer school begins.
  - Summer school is expected to be manageable and less stressful than the regular school year.

## Meditation Practice

Both Andy and Audel discussed their individual meditation practices and the benefits they have experienced.

- **Details**
  - Andy: Has been meditating more frequently and noticed his sessions now begin in a state of calm rather than requiring effort to settle.
  - Audel: Has been using short, even one-minute meditations as a reset tool during stressful periods.
  - Andy: Affirmed that using meditation as a grounding and calming method is a valid and valuable application of the practice.
  - Andy: Emphasized that the core purpose of Buddhist practice is to reduce suffering.
- **Conclusion**
  - Both participants agreed that consistent, even brief, meditation practice is beneficial for managing stress and maintaining equanimity.
  - A 15-minute shared meditation session was conducted during the meeting, after which Audel noted feeling significantly more relaxed.

## Visit to Abayagiri Monastery

Andy shared highlights from a recent visit to the Abayagiri monastery, including community interactions and upcoming events.

- **Details**
  - Andy: Visited Abayagiri monastery for an "Apaska Day" (Spiritual Friends Day), which is being reinstated monthly by Ajahn Nandico after a COVID-related hiatus.
  - Andy: Met a young aspiring monk who reminded him of a New Yorker, who is scheduled to be ordained the following Friday.
  - Andy: Shared wisdom from Ajahn Samedo to the young monk: "Don't make yourself a problem" — advice originally given in the context of meeting one's parents.
  - Andy: Reflected that this advice is universally applicable — when we make situations about ourselves, problems multiply.
  - Audel: Responded positively, noting he tries to live by a similar principle.
- **Conclusion**
  - The monastery is resuming regular monthly Spiritual Friends Days and will also be hosting retreats.
  - Andy plans to participate in upcoming retreats at Abayagiri.



## The Death of Expertise and Self-Reflection



Andy discussed a YouTube video and book that prompted personal self-reflection about humility and intellectual arrogance.

- **Details**
  - Andy: Came across a short video referencing *The Death of Expertise* by Thomas Nichols, which addresses the erosion of respect for established knowledge and the rise of anti-intellectualism.
  - Andy: Connected the book's theme to a personal moment at the monastery where he realized he was sharing opinions rather than asking questions of the Ajahn.
  - Andy: Used this as a "check yourself before you wreck yourself" moment, cautioning against arrogance or entitlement in spiritual and intellectual settings.
  - Audel: Acknowledged the relevance of the observation.
- **Conclusion**
  - Andy identified the importance of remaining humble and curious rather than positioning oneself as an expert, especially in spiritual settings.
  - The Buddhist principle of "not holding fixed views" was cited as a guiding reminder.

## Metta Sutta and Theravada Buddhist Chanting

Andy shared a chanting book from the Thai Forest Theravada tradition and highlighted key passages.

- **Details**
  - Andy: Shared a Google Drive link to the Theravada Chanting Book, Volume 1, used at Abayagiri monastery.
  - Andy: Directed Audel to pages 36–37, which contain the Metta Sutta (Loving-Kindness Chant).
  - Andy: Read aloud key lines: *"Humble and not conceited, contented and easily satisfied, unburdened with duties and frugal in their ways."*
  - Andy: Highlighted the closing lines referencing enlightenment: *"By not holding fixed views, the pure-hearted one, having clarity of vision, being freed from all sense desires, is not born again into this world."*
  - Andy: Compared the Metta Sutta's significance in Buddhism to the "Our Father" prayer in Christianity.
- **Conclusion**
  - Audel was granted access to the chanting book PDF for personal reference.
  - The Metta Sutta was presented as a foundational and beautiful expression of the Buddhist path.

## Reflections on Presence, Co-Regulation, and Compassion

Andy shared a personal story about visiting his father in a county hospital emergency room, drawing broader lessons about human presence and compassion.

- **Details**
  - Andy: Recounted reconnecting with his estranged father, who was on dialysis at a county hospital in Oakland.
  - Andy: Described how he responded to a tense situation between his grumpy father and a grumpy nurse by radiating warmth, gratitude, and love.
  - Andy: Noted that both his father and the nurse lightened up in response to his calm, loving presence.
  - Audel: Described this as "co-regulation" and affirmed the power of one's presence to shift the emotional environment.
  - Andy: Reflected that healthcare workers in under-resourced settings face chronic stress and trauma, which explains their demeanor.
- **Conclusion**
  - The story served as a "Dharma reminder" about the impact of one's presence and the importance of compassion in difficult environments.
  - Both participants acknowledged the role of chronic stress and poverty in shaping human behavior.



## Perspective on "Gold-Plated Problems"



Andy and Audel briefly reflected on the relative nature of their challenges compared to global suffering.

- **Details**
  - Andy: Coined the phrase "gold-plated problems" to describe the challenges faced by Americans relative to those experiencing war, extreme poverty, or lack of basic necessities.
  - Audel: Agreed, acknowledging the tendency to lose perspective.
  - Andy: Clarified he was not dismissing anyone's struggles, but noting that there are different levels of hardship.
- **Conclusion**
  - Both participants agreed on the value of maintaining perspective and gratitude.

## Camping Plans and Health Considerations

Andy briefly discussed plans for camping and noted health limitations related to smoke sensitivity.

- **Details**
  - Andy: Expressed excitement about camping now that he has no schedule restrictions in retirement.
  - Andy: Noted that sleeping on the ground is physically difficult and he uses a cot with a memory foam topper.
  - Andy: Shared that smoke from campfires and wildfires severely affects his respiratory health.
  - Andy: Recounted a past vision quest where wildfire smoke forced him to leave early and subsequently required an eight-hour emergency room visit for respiratory treatment.
- **Conclusion**
  - Andy plans to camp but will avoid campfires and take precautions regarding smoke exposure.

## Scheduling and Next Meeting

Andy and Audel reviewed their upcoming meeting schedule.

- **Details**
  - Andy: Noted that the following week's meeting falls on Memorial Day and proposed canceling it.
  - Audel: Agreed, citing family plans.
  - Andy: Confirmed the next meeting is scheduled for June 1st, before a planned trip to Joshua Tree.
  - Audel: Confirmed June 1st works and will notify Andy if anything changes.
- **Conclusion**
  - The Memorial Day week meeting was canceled.
  - Next meeting confirmed for June 1st.

## Challenges

- Andy's daughter is in rehabilitation 2.5 hours away, requiring significant travel and emotional energy.
- Andy's other daughter is facing an unplanned pregnancy with a partner whose reliability is uncertain.
- Audel has been managing sustained stress since April, navigating the end of the school year alongside personal family matters.
- Audel's wife is experiencing back pain from a long commute.
- Audel's oldest dog has congestive heart failure, requiring ongoing monitoring and preparation for end-of-life decisions.
- Andy has significant smoke sensitivity that limits outdoor activities and requires careful management.

## Action Items

- **Andy**
  - Share the Theravada Chanting Book PDF with Audel via Google Drive (grant viewer/download access). (Immediate)
  - Cancel the Memorial Day week meeting on the calendar. (Completed during meeting)
  - Confirm the June 1st meeting remains on the calendar. (Completed during meeting)
  - Look into attending upcoming retreats at Abayagiri monastery. (Ongoing)
  - Prepare camping gear, including cot and memory foam topper, for an upcoming camping trip. (Before camping trip)
- **Audel**





- Notify Andy if the June 1st meeting schedule changes. (Before June 1st)
- Continue leaning into meditation practice, including short sessions for stress management. (Ongoing)
- Attend the kindergarten graduation ceremony for his son on Wednesday. (Wednesday)
- Attend the prep day for summer school the Friday before June 1st. (Friday before June 1st)

[View in Zoom](#)

AI can make mistakes. Review for accuracy.

Please rate the accuracy of this summary.



---

Thank you for choosing Zoom,

**The Zoom Team**

---



[Zoom.com](https://zoom.us)

55 Almaden Blvd  
San Jose, CA 95113

[+1.888.799.9666](tel:+18887999666)

© 2026 Zoom Communications, Inc.

